



INSIDE saturday



HEISMAN WATCH

BY KYLE WOOD

TIER 1

ARCH MANNING QB • TEXAS

Manning (right) may not have lived up to the Heisman hype heaped on him last season, but don't discount what he did in Year 1 as the Longhorns' starter. He quite literally found his legs down the stretch, ending the season by showcasing the best of his dual-threat abilities. Manning will benefit from throwing to the best wide receiver room in the country. And with Steve Sarkisian scheming him up, his stats could explode.

CJ CARR QB • NOTRE DAME

The moment was never too big for Carr as a freshman. And with all-world running back Jeremiah Love gone, the Fighting Irish will rely on Carr's arm much more often this season.

TRINIDAD CHAMBLISS QB • OLE MISS

Chambliss won an eligibility battle to extend a unique career that saw him dominate both Division II and the SEC. His stats, once he took over for the Rebels, were otherworldly. Though Chambliss will be in a new system with fresh faces, the smart money is on him dazzling once again.





TIER 1, CONT.

JULIAN SAYIN QB • OHIO STATE

Sayin earned an invite to New York for his uber-efficient Buckeyes debut. With Arthur Smith calling the plays and Jeremiah Smith still lined up outside, he could take his play up another level and bring home the hardware.

JOSH HOOVER QB • INDIANA

Curt Cignetti has established himself as a quarterback kingmaker. And Hoover — who threw for a ton of yards, touchdowns and interceptions at TCU — is next up. Doubt Hoover and the Hoosiers at your own peril.

DARIAN MENSAH QB • MIAMI (FLA.)

If you have any questions about Mensah's ability, consider how hard the Hurricanes went after him — and how hard Duke fought to keep him. Miami is in the business of transfer portal quarterbacks. And based on Mensah's production, it looks like the Canes got another good one.

DANTE MOORE QB • OREGON

Moore opted to wait on the NFL and return for another season in college after establishing himself as one of the best players in the country. He has the talent — and the weapons in place around him — to become the Ducks' second Heisman winner.

JEREMIAH SMITH WR • OHIO STATE

Smith is widely considered the best player in college football. After two Biletnikoff Award snubs and no real Heisman consideration, don't be surprised if this is the year he goes scorched earth.

TIER 2

BEAR BACHMEIER QB, BYU

Bachmeier accounted for 3,560 yards of total offense and 26 total touchdowns, becoming only the second freshman quarterback in BYU's storied history at the position to throw for 3,000-plus yards (3,033).

SAM LEAVITT QB, LSU

Leavitt was the biggest get out of the portal for Lane Kiffin's first Tigers team. Assuming good health, there will be offensive fireworks in Baton Rouge.

JAYDEN MAIAVA QB, USC

No program has collected more Heismans than the Trojans. And Lincoln Riley is responsible for a few wins as well. If Maiava has truly mastered this offense, eye-popping stats are sure to follow.

JOHN MATEER QB, OKLAHOMA

It looked like the Heisman was Mateer's award to win last season before he underwent surgery and Fernando Mendoza took off. Mateer must recapture that September magic to be in the mix.

MARCEL REED QB, TEXAS A&M

If Reed takes another leap as a passer and maintains his mobility, the Aggies should be successful enough to keep him in contention.

GUNNER STOCKTON QB, GEORGIA

Stockton is the definition of solid, and his Bulldogs might just reassert themselves as the best team in the country when it's all said and done.

DON'T FORGET ABOUT

■ **Rocco Becht • QB, Penn State** Becht has ample starting experience and rare familiarity with his new Nittany Lions teammates.

■ **Kewan Lacy • RB, Ole Miss** A touchdown machine, Lacy returns to the Rebels ready for an even larger workload.

■ **Austin Mack/Keelon Russell • QB, Alabama** The winner of the Crimson Tide quarterback battle could put up big numbers in this system.

■ **LaNorris Sellers • QB, South Carolina** Sellers struggled last season — but at his best, he possesses a rare combination of size and speed.

■ **Malachi Toney • WR, Miami (Fla.)** Toney set records as a true freshman. The sky is the limit for a player with that kind of speed.

■ **Bryce Underwood • QB, Michigan** Underwood showed flashes of brilliance as a true freshman, and he might be ready to take a major leap in 2026.

■ **Demond Williams Jr. • QB, Washington** He flirted with the transfer portal, but it turns out that Williams is sticking around. Can the Huskies maximize his unique abilities?

LONGSHOTS

Byrum Brown • QB, Auburn | Cam Coleman • WR, Texas | Devon Dampier • QB, Utah | Mark Fletcher Jr. • RB, Miami (Fla.) | Ahmad Hardy • RB, Missouri | Bo Jackson • RB, Ohio State | Avery Johnson • QB, Kansas State | Drew Mestemaker • QB, Oklahoma State | Aaron Philo • QB, Florida | Jaron-Keawe Sagapolutele • QB, Cal | Conner Weigman • QB, Houston



10 BEST GAMES OF 2026

BY KYLE WOOD



1

OHIO STATE AT TEXAS (SEPT. 12)

You might recall that the Longhorns' trip to the Horseshoe last season also took the top spot. The Buckeyes won a slugfest, which didn't do anything to dampen expectations for the return trip. Both teams once again have title aspirations, with Heisman favorites Arch Manning and Julian Sayin at the forefront. And now, Manning has Cam Coleman to counter Sayin's connection with Jeremiah Smith. Can Ohio State make it three in a row? Or will Texas stop the skid at home?



2. OHIO STATE AT INDIANA (OCT. 17)

The Hoosiers turned the tide of a series that the Buckeyes have long dominated. Indiana's first win over Ohio State in decades was a key checkpoint on its path to an undefeated season and first national title. Indiana head coach Curt Cignetti's success seems sustainable. And the arrival of another loaded transfer class could help the Hoosiers maintain their perch atop the Big Ten — but not if Ryan Day and Co. have something to say about it.

3. MIAMI (FLA.) AT NOTRE DAME (NOV. 7)

Much has been made of last season's meeting between the Hurricanes and Fighting Irish. Miami's win propelled

it to the College Football Playoff for the first time and kept Notre Dame out, much to the chagrin of some folks in South Bend. After all that talk, quarterback CJ Carr and the Irish have a shot at revenge when the Canes come to town with transfer quarterback Darian Mensah leading the charge.

4. LSU AT OLE MISS (SEPT. 19)

The Tigers and Rebels already didn't like each other, and Lane Kiffin's unceremonious exit for LSU from the best team in Ole Miss history ratcheted the rivalry up a few notches ahead of his return. Lost in the fracas is the fact that this should be a very good game between the lines, in addition to all the storylines. This is about as high stakes as a Saturday in September gets.

5. MICHIGAN AT OHIO STATE (NOV. 28)

The Buckeyes ended their losing streak in the series with a resounding win in '25, setting the stage for Ohio State to take back control of this epic rivalry. However, the arrival of new Michigan head coach Kyle Whittingham and the development of quarterback Bryce Underwood throw an interesting wrinkle into the 122nd iteration of The Game.

6. OREGON AT OHIO STATE (NOV. 7)

Quarterback Dante Moore's return keeps the Ducks on par with the Buckeyes. There's a fair chance this trip to the Horseshoe is the only game all season in which Oregon will be an underdog, and it could have an outsized impact on the Big Ten race and CFP seeding.

7. GEORGIA AT OLE MISS (NOV. 7)

The Rebels are the only SEC team not named Alabama to beat the Bulldogs since 2021. That includes Ole Miss' epic CFP win on New Year's Day 2026. Head coaches Kirby Smart and Pete Golding bring back the bulk of their rosters from that Sugar Bowl classic.

8. TEXAS AT TEXAS A&M (NOV. 27)

Even beyond the potential SEC and CFP implications — which are massive — the Aggies need a win just to regain bragging rights. Texas A&M hasn't beaten the Longhorns since 2010 (although the teams have met only three times since then).

9. GEORGIA AT ALABAMA (OCT. 10)

The Bulldogs had struggled against the Crimson Tide — that is, until Georgia blew out Bama in last season's SEC Championship Game, a stark reminder that the league still runs through Athens. But for all of the Dawgs' success, they haven't won in Tuscaloosa since 2007.

10. TEXAS VS. OKLAHOMA (OCT. 10)

Steve Sarkisian has had Brent Venables' number as long as they've been at their respective schools. However, OU weathered a lopsided loss in the Red River Rivalry a season ago to return to the CFP, while Texas stayed home. Neither team can afford a loss this season.

FROM TOP: ADAM CAIRNS - IMAGN IMAGES, GRACE SMITH/INDYSTAR

↔ TOP TRANSFERS

BY STEVEN LASSAN



QB DREW MESTEMAKER

OKLAHOMA STATE
FROM NORTH TEXAS

Mestemaker threw for 4,379 yards and 34 touchdowns in a breakout season at North Texas in '25. By following head coach Eric Morris to Oklahoma State, Mestemaker should make a seamless transition and be one of the Big 12's top quarterbacks this fall.



QB DARIAN MENSAB

MIAMIA (FLA.) FROM DUKE

Mensah's late entry into the portal solved Miami's biggest question mark. He threw for 3,973 yards and 34 touchdowns in leading Duke to an ACC championship last season.

QB JACKSON ARNOLD

UNLV from Auburn

The former 5-star aims to get his career back on track in head coach Dan Mullen's high-powered offense after struggling in previous stops at Oklahoma and Auburn.

QB ALONZA BARNETT III

UCF from James Madison

Barnett's mobility should help jumpstart a UCF offense that ranked 13th in the Big 12 in scoring.

QB ROCCO BECHT

Penn State from Iowa State

After throwing for 9,000-plus yards at Iowa State, Becht followed head coach Matt Campbell to Penn State.

QB CUTTER BOLEY

Arizona State from Kentucky

Boley threw for 2,160 yards and 15 touchdowns in a promising redshirt freshman performance for a struggling Kentucky offense last season.

QB BYRUM BROWN

Auburn from South Florida

Brown led the nation in total offense last season (347.2 ypg) and should have a seamless transition to the SEC after following head coach Alex Golesh to the Plains.

QB AIDAN CHILES

Northwestern from Michigan St.

Northwestern marks Chiles' third stop after previous stints at Oregon State and Michigan State. Chiles lost the starting job in East Lansing, but a chance to work under new offensive coordinator Chip Kelly in Evanston should get his career back on track.

QB ANTHONY COLANDREA

Nebraska from UNLV

The combination of Colandrea's playmaking ability and offensive coordinator Dana Holgorsen's scheme should make for an intriguing pairing.

QB ASHTON DANIELS

Florida State from Auburn

Daniels struggled in a previous stint at Stanford but averaged 321.7 total yards per game in three starts at Auburn last November.

QB WALKER EGET

Duke from San José State

Eget provides Duke with an experienced option after Darian Mensah's late decision to transfer to Miami (Fla.).

QB BILLY EDWARDS JR.

North Carolina from Wisconsin

Head coach Bill Belichick hopes the combination of Edwards and new play-caller Bobby Petrino brings life to an offense that averaged only 19.3 points per game in '25.

QB JC FRENCH IV

Cincinnati from Georgia Southern

French threw for nearly 6,000 yards across 36 games at Georgia Southern.

QB JADEN CRAIG

TCU from Harvard

Craig replaces Josh Hoover at the controls of TCU's high-powered offense. The FCS Harvard transfer was a finalist for the Walter Payton Award after throwing for 2,869 yards and 25 touchdowns last year.

QB ETHAN GRUNKEMEYER

Virginia Tech from Penn State

Grunkemeyer was pressed into action after an early-season injury to starter Drew Allar at Penn State last year. Grunkemeyer finished on a high note by throwing seven touchdowns over his final five games. Following head coach James Franklin to Blacksburg should ensure an easy transition.

QB MICHAEL HAWKINS JR.

West Virginia from Oklahoma

Hawkins possesses the rushing ability and athleticism to thrive in head coach Rich Rodriguez's offense.

QB KATIN HOUSER

Illinois from East Carolina

Houser ranked third in the American Conference in passing yards per game (275) and hit six completions of 50-plus yards last season.

QB JOSH HOOVER
INDIANA FROM TCU



Hoover has big shoes to fill, replacing Heisman Trophy winner Fernando Mendoza. However, the TCU transfer is up to the task after throwing for 9,629 yards and 71 touchdowns across 36 games with the Horned Frogs. The Texas native should be an excellent fit in head coach Curt Cignetti's offense.

QB COLTON JOSEPH

Wisconsin from Old Dominion

Joseph was one of the nation's most dynamic signal-callers last season, averaging 302.6 total yards per game in 12 starts. The Badgers hope he's the key cog in turning around an offense that averaged only 12.8 points per game in '25.

QB LINCOLN KIENHOLZ

Louisville from Ohio State

Kienholz has limited experience (36 career pass attempts), but head coach Jeff Brohm is intrigued by the former 4-star prospect's upside.

QB DJ LAGWAY

Baylor from Florida

Talent isn't a question with Lagway. However, his play declined in '25 due to injuries, and he's tossed 23 interceptions over the past two years. A fresh start could help Lagway get his career back on track.

QB HUSAN LONGSTREET

LSU from USC

Longstreet — a 5-star prospect in the '25 signing class — joins LSU after one season at USC. He could be a valuable insurance policy if Sam Leavitt's foot injury is a concern.

QB GIO LOPEZ

Wake Forest from North Carolina

After a disappointing year at North Carolina, Lopez is poised to rebound at Wake Forest with his

former South Alabama offensive coordinator (Rob Ezell) calling the plays in Winston-Salem.

QB ALBERTO MENDOZA

Georgia Tech from Indiana

Alberto — the brother of former Indiana star Fernando Mendoza — impressed in limited snaps with the Hoosiers and has a clear path to the starting job at Georgia Tech.

QB KENNY MINCHEY

Kentucky from Notre Dame

Minchey now gets to work with one of college football's top offensive minds in new Kentucky head coach Will Stein.

QB AARON PHILO

Florida from Georgia Tech

Tramell Jones Jr. pushed for the No. 1 job in the spring, but Philo's familiarity with new offensive coordinator Buster Faulkner is a huge asset.

QB BEAU PRIBULA

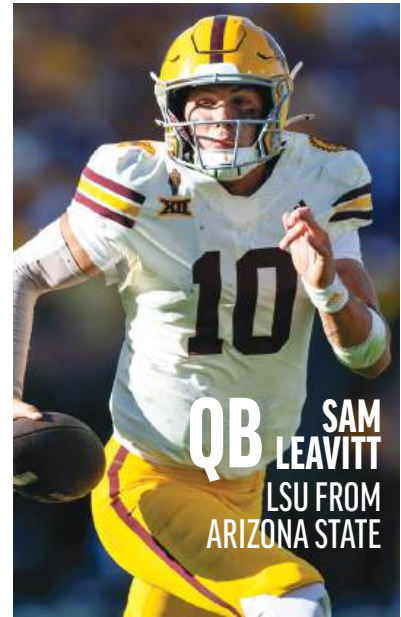
Virginia from Missouri

Pribula has the inside track to replace Chandler Morris after accounting for 17 total touchdowns in 10 games at Missouri last year.

QB DYLAN RAIOLA

Oregon from Nebraska

Raiola is taking a different path than most transfers. Instead of transferring for a No. 1 job, the two-year starter at Nebraska went to Oregon to sit behind Dante Moore and de-



QB SAM LEAVITT
LSU FROM ARIZONA STATE

Leavitt's recovery from a season-ending foot injury at Arizona State is one of the top SEC storylines entering '26. If he's healthy, Leavitt's mix of arm talent and mobility, along with head coach Lane Kiffin's offense, should propel the junior to a spot among the top quarterbacks in college football.

velop in anticipation of '27.

QB JAYLEN RAYNOR

Iowa State from Arkansas State

Raynor accumulated nearly 10,000 yards of total offense in three years at Arkansas State. He's a key cog in a rebuilt Iowa State offense.

QB AUSTIN SIMMONS

Missouri from Ole Miss

Simmons has all of the tools to develop into a high-level SEC starter. Can Missouri get the most out of his talent?

QB BRENDAN SORSBY

Texas Tech from Cincinnati

Sorsby has all of the tools, but a gambling investigation might prevent him from seeing the field this season.

QB MICHAEL VAN BUREN JR.

South Florida from LSU

After stints at LSU and Mississippi State, Van Buren has the potential to emerge as one of the American's top quarterbacks in South Florida's spread attack.

FROM LEFT: RICH JANZARUK/HERALD-TIMES; MARK J. REBILAS-IMAGNI IMAGES



RB CALEB HAWKINS

OKLAHOMA STATE FROM NORTH TEXAS

Hawkins followed head coach Eric Morris to Oklahoma State after rushing for 1,434 yards and 25 touchdowns at North Texas in '25.

RB CAM COOK

West Virginia from Jacksonville State

Cook led all FBS players with 1,659 rushing yards last season and lands in one of the most running back-friendly offenses in the nation.

RB JUSTICE HAYNES

Georgia Tech from Michigan

Haynes is set to team with Malachi Hosley to form one of the ACC's top backfields.

RB MAKHI HUGHES

Houston from Oregon

Hughes had back-to-back 1,000-yard seasons at Tulane in 2023-24. He tallied only 17 carries with Oregon but is poised to handle the bulk of the carries for Houston.

RB HOLLYWOOD SMOTHERS

Texas from NC State

Smothers and fellow transfer Raleek Brown (Arizona State) are set to anchor an improved Longhorn ground game.

WR MYLAN GRAHAM

Notre Dame from Ohio State

The arrival of Graham and fellow Ohio State transfer Quincy Porter



WR CAM COLEMAN

TEXAS FROM AUBURN

Coleman's elite physical talent and big-play ability should shine at Texas after two years of inconsistent quarterback play at Auburn.

adds more weapons to a loaded Fighting Irish offense for quarterback CJ Carr.

WR NICK MARSH

Indiana from Michigan State

Marsh accumulated 1,311 receiving yards in two seasons. His arrival alleviates concern over key departures at receiver for Curt Cignetti.

OL LANCE HEARD

Kentucky from Tennessee

Heard's arrival gives new quarterback Kenny Minchey a reliable blindside protector and is a key piece in Kentucky's hopes to rebuild the "Big Blue Wall."

OL JACARRIUS PEAK

South Carolina from NC State

A spring injury may sideline Peak early in the '26 season. The 32-game starter at NC State is expected to anchor a rebuilt and improved South Carolina line.

OL JORDAN SEATON

LSU from Colorado

Seaton played right away as a true freshman at Colorado and shined over 22 starts. He's a key cog in a rebuilt LSU offensive line.

DL CHAZ COLEMAN

Tennessee from Penn State

Coleman followed defensive coordinator Jim Knowles from Happy Valley to Rocky Top. He's just scratching the surface of his potential.

DL JOHN HENRY DALEY

Michigan from Utah

Daley (11.5 sacks last year) is on track for a full recovery after a torn Achilles ended his '25 season.

DL JAMES SMITH

Ohio State from Alabama

Smith and Qua Russaw are instant-impact contributors from Alabama on an Ohio State defensive line replacing three key starters.

DL PRINCEWILL UMANMIELEN

LSU from Ole Miss

After a breakout '25 season, Umanmielen followed Lane Kiffin to Baton Rouge. The senior is one of the SEC's top returning pass-rushers.

DL TREY WHITE

Texas Tech from San Diego State

White headlines eight Red Raider transfer additions to the defensive line. He has accumulated 19.5 sacks over the past two years.

DL DAMON WILSON II

Miami (Fla.) from Missouri

Wilson's ability to get to the QB (nine sacks in '25) helps compensate for the loss of Rueben Bain Jr. and Akheem Mesidor to the NFL.

LB RASHEEM BILES

Texas from Pitt

Biles projects as the top transfer linebacker after back-to-back All-ACC seasons and 32 tackles for a loss during that span at Pitt.

DB TY BENEFIELD

LSU from Boise State

Benefield's versatility in defending the run and pass will be a huge asset for a rebuilt LSU secondary.

DB KOI PERICH

Oregon from Minnesota

Perich should be a seamless replacement for All-America safety Dillon Thieneman on the back end.



GRADING 2026'S NEW HEAD COACHES

BY STEVEN LASSAN



1 LANE KIFFIN LSU

Kiffin has navigated the new transfer portal and NIL rules as well as any coach in college football. After going 55-19 at

Ole Miss with three consecutive seasons of double-digit victories, Kiffin was brought to Baton Rouge with one goal in mind: a national championship. The Bayou Bengals are sparing no expense on the talent acquisition front, and Kiffin should have no trouble keeping Louisiana's top recruits at home. **GRADE: A+**



2 KYLE WHITTINGHAM MICHIGAN

Whittingham wasn't out of a job long following his decision to step down at Utah. The 66-year-old coach brings a needed steady hand to Ann Arbor, while Michigan offers Whittingham an opportunity to chase the only missing pieces on his résumé: a College Football Playoff berth and a national championship. **GRADE: A+**



3 JAMES FRANKLIN VIRGINIA TECH

Franklin was dismissed at Penn State in 2025 after a 3-3 start to a season in which the program expected to contend for a national title. Franklin's struggles in big games are notable, but his ability to win overall at a high level should turn Virginia Tech into an ACC title contender. **GRADE: A**

4. Jon Sumrall, Florida Sumrall won at least nine games in every season as a head coach in stops at Troy (2022-23) and Tulane (2024-25) and compiled a 43-12 record overall. After taking the Green Wave to an appearance in the College Football Playoff last year, Sumrall's next task is to help Florida get back on track on the national level. **GRADE: A**

5. Eric Morris, Oklahoma State North Texas displayed steady improvement under Morris' watch, finishing 12-2 with one of the nation's most prolific offenses in 2025. Morris is bringing a handful of key players from that Mean Green squad, including quarterback Drew Mestemaker and running back Caleb Hawkins. The Cowboys could be the most-improved team in the nation in 2026. **GRADE: A**

6. Matt Campbell, Penn State The Ohio native thrived at one of the toughest power-conference jobs in the nation, recording a 72-55 mark and seven bowl trips at Iowa State. Campbell knows how to get the most out of a roster, but expectations in Happy Valley will be higher than they were in Ames. **GRADE: A**

7. Bob Chesney, UCLA Chesney has won at every level, including a 21-6 mark at James Madison over the past two seasons and a trip to the College Football Playoff in 2025. In stints with the Dukes, Div. III Salve Regina, Div. II Assumption and FCS Holy Cross, Chesney is 132-52 overall as a head coach. **GRADE: A**

8. Charles Huff, Memphis With significant ties to the Southeast and a track record of success as a recruiter and head coach at two different FBS jobs (Southern Miss and Marshall), Huff looks like the right pick to help Memphis challenge for a College Football Playoff spot in the near future. **GRADE: A**

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP: MATTHEW HINTON - MAGN IMAGES; BRIAN BISHOP - MAGN IMAGES; JUNFU HAN



9. Alex Golesh, Auburn Golesh emerged as one of the top coaches in the Group of 6 ranks, guiding South Florida to a 23-15 record over the past three seasons. Golesh's background of producing prolific offenses should provide instant help on the Plains. The Tigers have not finished higher than ninth in the SEC in scoring over the past six seasons. **GRADE: A**



10 WILL STEIN KENTUCKY

Stein provides a much-needed breath of fresh air after the program had grown stale. The former Louisville quarterback and Kentucky native coordinated some of the nation's top offenses at Oregon over the past three seasons and already put his stamp on the Wildcats with a standout transfer class. **GRADE: A-**

11. Collin Klein, Kansas State Klein is back at his alma mater following a successful two-year stint as Texas A&M's offensive coordinator. This is his first head-coaching opportunity, but the former K-State quarterback knows what it takes to win in Manhattan and is among the top offensive minds in the nation. **GRADE: A-**

12. Jim Mora, Colorado State Mora guided UConn to a 27-23 mark from 2022-25, including back-to-back nine-win campaigns in his final two years in charge. Mora is tasked with helping Colorado State reach its potential, especially as it moves to the Pac-12 this fall. **GRADE: B+**

13. Jimmy Rogers, Iowa State In two seasons in charge at South Dakota State (2023-24), Rogers guided the program to a 27-3 record and won the 2023 FCS National Championship. Rogers was hired at Washington State last season and took a revamped roster to a solid 6-6 season with a bowl appearance. He looks like a strong fit to replace Matt Campbell in Ames. **GRADE: B+**

14. Pete Golding, Ole Miss Golding's tenure is just a few months old, but he's already off to a good start after guiding Ole Miss to two College Football Playoff victories following Lane Kiffin's departure to LSU. Additionally, Golding held on to a couple of key cogs from the 2025 team and brought in one of the SEC's top portal classes to help this program push for a national title. **GRADE: B+**



15 BRIAN HARTLINE SOUTH FLORIDA

Hartline was arguably college football's top wide receivers coach during an eight-year run as an assistant at Ohio State. He was also highly regarded for his work on the recruiting trail — including in the talent-rich state of Florida — which should prove valuable in his new role with the Bulls. **GRADE: B+**

16. Mike Jacobs, Toledo Jacobs is arguably the best under-the-radar hire for '26. He's won at three different jobs at three different levels of college football, compiling a 94-23 mark as a head coach since 2016. Jacobs — a former Ohio State offensive lineman — returns to his home state of Ohio after going 20-6 at Mercer with two FCS Playoff appearances. **GRADE: B+**



17 MORGAN SCALLEY UTAH

Kyle Whittingham leaves big shoes to fill, but Scalley is ready to run his own program. The Salt Lake City native was a standout defensive back for the Utes (2001-04) and has worked as an assistant under Whittingham since 2007. After a promotion to defensive coordinator in 2016, Scalley was instrumental in assembling some of the nation's top units. **GRADE: B**

18. Pat Fitzgerald, Michigan State Fitzgerald returns to a Big Ten sideline for the first time since his dismissal at Northwestern due to hazing allegations surrounding the program. Fitzgerald was later cleared of any wrongdoing. The former Wildcats linebacker went 110-101 overall and posted three seasons of at least 10 victories at his alma mater from 2006-22. **GRADE: B-**

19. Billy Napier, James Madison After a failed stint at Florida, Napier wasted no time in returning to the sidelines at one of the top Group of 6 jobs in the nation. Recruiting top-notch talent to Gainesville was never a problem for Napier, who previously went 40-12 as the head coach at Louisiana from 2018-21. **GRADE: B-**

A+ GRADING 2026'S NEW HEAD COACHES, CONT.

20. Jason Candle, UConn Candle has been considered a rising star in the Group of 6 coaching ranks, going 81-44 with two MAC titles during his tenure at Toledo. Candle's background on offense, along with his overall success at Toledo, should help UConn build on the program's 18 wins over the past two years. **GRADE: B-**

21. Tosh Lupoi, Cal Lupoi's first opportunity as a head coach comes at his alma mater. The former Cal defensive lineman spent the past four years as Oregon's defensive coordinator and previously coached as an assistant at Alabama (2014-18) and in the NFL (2019-21). **GRADE: B-**

22. Mark Carney, Kent State Carney earned the full-time job after guiding Kent State to a 5-7 record as the interim in 2025. This is one of the toughest jobs in college football, but Carney's ability to get the most out of the roster in a challenging situation provides optimism that he can steer this team into annual bowl contention. **GRADE: B-**

23. Blake Anderson, Southern Miss Anderson is a proven winner at the Group of 6 level, but he brings baggage to this role. His last head-coaching stint with Utah State ended after an investigation indicated he did not comply with the school's Title IX policies. **GRADE: B-**

24. Neal Brown, North Texas Brown was considered a rising star after guiding Troy to a 35-16 record from 2015-18. However, that success failed to translate at West Virginia (only one winning season prior to his dismissal in 2024). Brown's ability to reload a roster will be tested right away with an incoming class of 50-plus transfers. **GRADE: B-**

25. Ryan Silverfield, Arkansas Silverfield posted a solid overall 50-25 mark at Memphis, including a 29-9 record over the past three years, and has displayed a knack for successfully building rosters in the transfer portal era. However, this won't be an easy rebuilding project, as Arkansas needs more resources to compete at a high level in the SEC. **GRADE: B-**



26 KIRBY MOORE WASHINGTON STATE

The 35-year-old former Boise State receiver is tasked with bringing some much-needed stability to the program in the new Pac-12. Moore — a native of Washington — arrives in Pullman after working as the offensive coordinator at Missouri since 2023. **GRADE: B-**

27. Ryan Beard, Coastal Carolina Beard is a solid hire for a Coastal Carolina program looking to get back on track after back-to-back losing seasons. The former WKU defensive back went 19-16 at Missouri State and successfully guided the program through a transition from the FCS to the FBS. **GRADE: B-**

28. JaMarcus Shephard, Oregon State Shephard was regarded as one of college football's top wide receiver coaches and has accumulated a wealth of experience as an assistant from stops at WKU, Washington State, Purdue, Washington and Alabama. His energy and passion should bring a much-needed fresh start to Corvallis. **GRADE: B-**

29. Casey Woods, Missouri State Woods lands his first head-coaching job after spending the past four years as SMU's offensive coordinator. The Mustangs averaged 30-plus points per game every year under Woods, who also has previous stops as an assistant at Missouri, UAB, Arkansas State and Auburn. **GRADE: B-**

30. Will Hall, Tulane After back-to-back home-run hires in Willie Fritz and Jon Sumrall, Tulane opted for continuity by promoting Hall. The Mississippi native previously worked with the Green Wave as an assistant from 2019-20 and again in '25. This stop is Hall's fourth chance as a head coach, although his last stop at Southern Miss did not go well (14-30 overall). **GRADE: C+**

31. Tavita Pritchard, Stanford The Washington native played quarterback for the Cardinal from 2006-09 and later worked on the Farm as an assistant coach from 2010-22, including the past five seasons as offensive coordinator. After spending the past three years as the Washington Commanders' quarterback coach, Pritchard returns to Stanford as former teammate Andrew Luck's first hand-picked head coach. **GRADE: C**

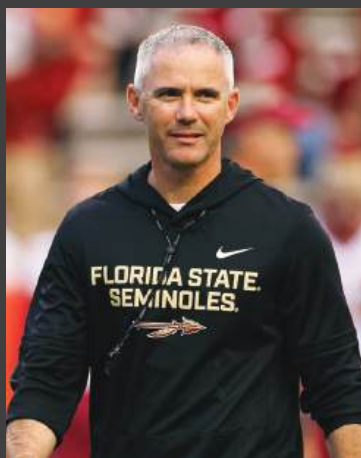
32. Alonzo Carter, Sacramento State Carter — a former backup dancer for MC Hammer and long-time assistant coach — is tasked with navigating Sacramento State through its FBS transition. The California native's extensive roots throughout the state should help attract talent to the newest FBS program. Carter spent the past two seasons at Arizona working with the team's running backs. **GRADE: C**

33. John Hauser, Ohio Ohio opted for continuity with Hauser's promotion from defensive coordinator to head coach following Brian Smith's dismissal prior to the team's appearance in the Frisco Bowl. It's hard to argue with that approach considering the Bobcats have made a postseason appearance in nine out of the past 11 years. **GRADE: C**

34. Alex Mortensen, UAB Mortensen had some bright spots as UAB's offensive coordinator over the past three years, but this is a steep learning curve for a first-time head coach at one of college football's toughest jobs. **GRADE: C-**

COACHES ON THE HOT SEAT

BY STEVEN LASSAN



1 MIKE NORVELL FLORIDA STATE

A hefty buyout (more than \$50 million) is likely the only thing that saved Norvell from a firing at the end of 2025. After going 23-4 with an ACC title from 2022-23, the Seminoles are just 7-17 overall and 3-13 in ACC play over the past two seasons. Florida State has not won a road game since '23.



2 LUKE FICKELL WISCONSIN

Fickell's future was the subject of debate after a 4-8 finish last season, which dropped Wisconsin to back-to-back losing marks for the first time since 1991-92. But instead of a coaching change, the Badgers opted to increase their roster investment and provide Fickell with all of the resources to turn around a program that's just 17-21 under his watch.



3. DAVE ARANDA, BAYLOR

Aranda set the bar high with a 12-2 record and Big 12 title in his second season (2021) in Waco. But the Bears have struggled since that breakthrough year, posting losing records in three out of the past four seasons and a 15-21 mark in Big 12 play. Aranda is regarded as one of the top defensive minds in college football, but Baylor has ranked at or near the bottom of the Big 12 in points allowed for three consecutive years.



4. MIKE LOCKSLEY, MARYLAND

Locksley seemed to have Maryland trending in the right direction with three consecutive winning seasons and bowl appearances from 2021-23. But the Terrapins have slid in the wrong direction since that three-year run, finishing 8-16 with just two Big Ten victories since '24. Recruiting talent to College Park hasn't been an issue for Locksley. However, with a 16-43 record in Big Ten play since '19, along with back-to-back losing seasons, the pressure is at an all-time high in College Park.

5. Dell McGee, Georgia State

With extensive ties to the Peach State, along with stints as an assistant at Georgia Southern and Georgia, McGee seemed like a slam-dunk hire prior to '24. But the former Auburn defensive back is just 4-20 overall in two seasons and has only one victory (1-15) in Sun Belt action.

6. Derek Mason, Middle Tennessee

Mason's hire was met with plenty of optimism in 2024, but the former Vanderbilt head coach has been a massive disappointment. The Blue Raiders are just 6-18 overall and 4-12 in Conference USA action over the past two seasons. Additionally, Mason's background on defense has yet to show on the field, as Middle Tennessee has ranked near the bottom of the conference in points allowed.

7. Shane Beamer, South Carolina

South Carolina surged into College Football Playoff contention with a nine-win season in '24, which fueled optimism heading into last year. But largely due to an ineffective offense, the Gamecocks regressed to 4-8 — their worst record under Beamer — with just one victory in SEC play. A revamped offensive staff should help Beamer get South Carolina back on track. But a third losing record in four years could spell the end of his tenure in Columbia.

8. Bill O'Brien, Boston College

After a promising 7-6 debut at Boston College in '24, O'Brien slumped to 2-10 with just one victory in ACC play last year. Six of the Eagles' losses came by 14 points or more, with O'Brien's offense averaging only 20.8 points in ACC games last year.

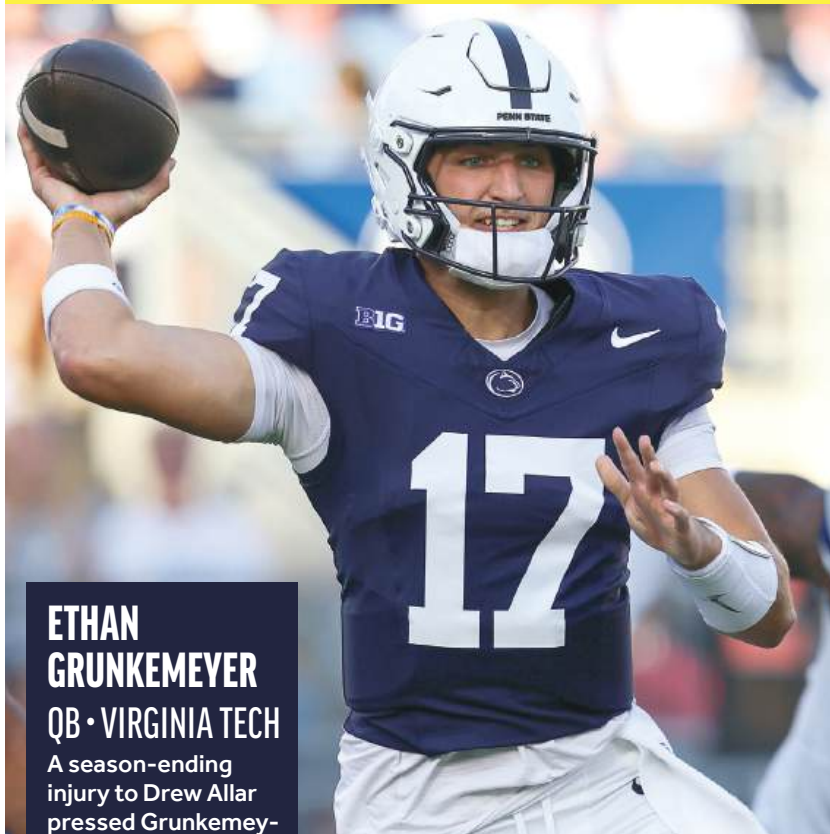
GETTING WARM

Bill Belichick, North Carolina
Jeff Choate, Nevada
Jeff Leiby, Mississippi State
Lincoln Riley, USC
Scott Satterfield, Cincinnati
Jay Sawvel, Wyoming
Scotty Walden, UTEP



BREAKOUT PLAYERS

BY STEVEN LASSAN



ETHAN GRUNKEMEYER QB • VIRGINIA TECH

A season-ending injury to Drew Allar pressed Grunkemeyer into action midway through the '25 campaign at Penn State. After a couple of tough learning experiences in road trips to Iowa and Ohio State, Grunkemeyer finished the year on a high note by throwing for 996 yards and seven touchdowns with only one interception over his final five games. The Ohio native followed former Penn State head coach James Franklin to Blacksburg via the portal. If Grunkemeyer picks up where he left off in December, he will rank among the ACC's top signal-callers in '26.

KEELON RUSSELL QB, ALABAMA

Austin Mack and Russell were locked in a tight spring battle to replace Ty Simpson, but Russell may have pulled ahead after an impressive showing in Alabama's final scrimmage. The former No. 2-ranked prospect in the nation flashed big-time talent in limited snaps in '25 and has all the tools.

BRYCE UNDERWOOD QB, MICHIGAN

Underwood started all 13 games as a true freshman last year, throwing for 2,428 yards and 11 touchdowns and adding 392 yards and six scores on the ground. New play-caller Jason Beck should help 2025's top overall recruit reach his potential with a much-improved Michigan attack.

ANEYAS WILLIAMS RB, NOTRE DAME

After waiting patiently behind Jeremiah Love and Jadarian Price over the past two seasons, Williams is finally poised to handle the bulk of the carries in South Bend. Over the past two years, Williams has averaged 7.6 yards per carry on 58 attempts.

REED HARRIS WR, ARIZONA STATE

Harris transferred to Arizona State after three seasons at Boston College, including

a productive '25 that included 39 receptions for 673 yards. The Montana native created buzz all spring for his highlight-reel catches and overall play in his first offseason with the Sun Devils.

TANOOK HINES WR, USC

Hines is expected to be a key weapon for quarterback Jayden Maiava this fall after an impressive freshman campaign. In 13 games, Hines grabbed 34 receptions for 561 yards and two scores, with six catches going for 30-plus yards.

JAMARI JOHNSON TE, OREGON

With Kenyon Sadiq off to the NFL, Johnson will be an even bigger cog in Oregon's passing game after recording 32 catches for 510 yards and three scores in '25.

MICHAEL FASUSI OL, OKLAHOMA

It's never easy starting as a true freshman in the SEC. But that's exactly what Fasusi did last year (10 starts). And now with a full offseason to develop under ace line coach Bill Bedenbaugh, Fasusi is primed to emerge as Oklahoma's anchor at left tackle.

ELIJAH GRIFFIN DL, GEORGIA

Griffin seems poised to join the Georgia DL-to-NFL pipeline in the near future after a freshman season that saw him record 22 tackles and one sack in limited snaps. He is just scratching the surface of his potential.

JUSTIN SCOTT DL, MIAMI (FLA.)

Scott — another former 5-star prospect — looks like the next standout in the trenches for head coach Mario Cristobal. He accumulated 6.5 tackles for a loss over 15 games and played a key role in Miami's stout run defense.

BYRON BALDWIN JR. DB, INDIANA

Baldwin became a key rotational piece as a true freshman in Indiana's standout secondary for the final nine contests. With another offseason to develop, Baldwin should become one of IU's top defenders.

MATTHEW O'HAREN-IMAGN IMAGES



RANKING THE CONFERENCES

BY KYLE WOOD



1. BIG TEN

The past three national champions all hail from the Big Ten. Michigan and Ohio State are traditional powers, and Indiana head coach Curt Cignetti isn't going anywhere. Conventional wisdom would say that Oregon has to break through one of these years. That's a strong contingent, while squads like USC, Iowa, Washington and Illinois make up a respectable second tier. In a conference this bloated, there will be bad teams, but the best of the Big Ten has the edge on the SEC's elite until proven otherwise.

2. SEC

For all the talk of the SEC being left in the dust, it's still home to many of the sport's top programs. Georgia is still the winningest team of this decade. The Texas hype may have just been a year ahead of schedule. And Texas A&M, LSU, Oklahoma, Ole Miss and Alabama all have playoff expectations. The SEC has a deep middle class, and coaching changes at lagging programs such as Florida and Auburn could elevate the conference back to the top spot. The league's national title drought should be over sooner rather than later.

3. BIG 12

Texas Tech — flush with cash and another loaded roster — remains the team to beat. BYU knows all too well that's a tall task. Utah and Houston were also humbled by the conference's new power. Those are the biggest threats to unseat the champs. Arizona and Arizona State can also throw a wrench into the race. Teams under new leadership, such as Kansas State and Oklahoma State, make for an interesting middle of the pack.

4. ACC

The ACC is top-heavy with Miami (Fla.) a clear favorite to win the league for the first time. Though there's a drop-off to the next tier of SMU and Louisville, it says a lot that the ceiling of the conference is a trip to the national championship game; that's more than the SEC or Big 12 can say lately. It would do the ACC well if Clemson and Florida State found their footing.

5. PAC-12

Oregon State and Washington State stuck around to see the conference of champions reincarnated. Some of the new faces figure to vault to the top right away. Boise State, Fresno State and San Diego State are all ready to win. Colorado State could soon join that class, too. There's no obvious bottom-feeder in the Pac-12, which is trying a unique schedule format in hopes of producing a playoff team.

6. AMERICAN The American was the only non-power conference untouched by realignment, though it did see more than a third of its coaches turn over. Can it withstand that brain drain and produce another CFP team? Navy is the favorite, while Memphis, South Florida and Tulane, which is coming off a breakthrough playoff berth, are all under new leadership.

7. MOUNTAIN WEST The Mountain West is almost unrecognizable after the latest round of realignment. San José State is the only active member that has won the league before. Boise State's exit opens the door for perennial runner-up UNLV. The Rebels are among the early CFP contenders in the Group of 6. Hawai'i and New Mexico project to have strong squads once again. Watch out if Air Force can get back on track and FCS powerhouse North Dakota State is ready for the FBS.

8. SUN BELT After the Sun Belt saw James Madison break through to the CFP, power conferences poached several of the league's top quarterbacks and coaches. The Dukes should stay competitive in the East with Georgia Southern and Old Dominion looming. Out West, newcomer Louisiana Tech can challenge Troy.

9. CONFERENCE USA Only half of CUSA was even in the FBS before this decade. Still, there's a solid core, especially if Liberty bounces back. Kennesaw State could have staying power, WKU is always in the mix, Jacksonville State has done nothing but win since its arrival, and Delaware could be ready to contend, too.

10. MAC Fewer than half of the MAC teams reached bowl eligibility last season as the chaotic conference crowned a new champion for the sixth year in a row. There's a top tier of Miami (Ohio), Toledo and reigning champ Western Michigan, but the worst of the MAC brings up the rear of the entire FBS.

15 THINGS



TO WATCH

IN 2026 ⇒ BY STEVEN LASSAN

1 NOTRE DAME'S 2026 REVENGE TOUR

Last year's College Football Playoff snub still stings months later in South Bend. So it's no surprise that Notre Dame opened spring practice with a simple motto: Leave No Doubt.

With 15 starters returning from last year's 10-win squad, along with a favorable schedule, leaving no doubt doesn't just mean a trip to the playoff. Instead, the Fighting Irish clearly have their sights set on ending a national title drought in South Bend that's lasted since 1988.

Quarterback CJ Carr took some early lumps but eventually tied for second nationally in yards per passing attempt (9.4) and threw 24 touchdowns in a standout freshman season. Carr's progression into one of the nation's elite quarterbacks is a big reason why head coach Marcus Freeman's program can win it all. There's no shortage of talent at receiver with Jaden Greathouse and Jordan Faison returning, along with former highly touted prospects Quincy Porter and Mylan Graham arriving from Ohio State via the transfer portal.

Running back Jeremiyah Love will be missed, but Aneyas Williams (7.6 yards per carry over 58 attempts) has flashed in limited time. Outside of replacing Love, Notre Dame's biggest concern is the offensive line. Two starters are gone, and key cogs in center Ashton Craig and tackle Charles Jagusah are on the mend after significant injuries in '25.

Like Carr, the defense took its share of early lumps. Under new coordinator Chris Ash, the Fighting Irish surrendered 98 points in the team's first three contests. This unit showed marked improvement the rest of the way by limiting opponents to 12.6 points per contest over the next nine games and allowing just 4.8 yards per snap for the entire '25 campaign. Notre Dame shouldn't need a transition period on this side of the ball this season, with eight starters back, including All-America cornerback Leonard Moore.

Notre Dame could be favored in 11 or all 12 of its games. The schedule features only three matchups against power-conference opponents — at BYU, Miami (Fla.) and SMU — that had a winning record in '25.

Thanks to a small playoff structure tweak for '26, the Fighting Irish simply need to be in the top 12 of the final ranking to be guaranteed a spot. But with a little extra motivation from last year's snub, a favorable schedule, an experienced two-deep and one of the nation's top quarterbacks in Carr, the goal in '26 isn't just to take a spot in the field. Instead, Freeman's team is set for a national-title-or-bust campaign.



2

BIG TEN DOMINANCE SET TO CONTINUE?

Thanks to its success in the BCS era and at the start of the new College Football Playoff format, the SEC held bragging rights over the rest of college football for years. However, things have shifted fast in the sport over the last few seasons. So while it still means more in the SEC, and the conference had arguably more depth than any other league, the Big Ten closed the gap to No. 1 — and it also has a strong case to take the title as the best conference in '26.

The ability to deploy NIL, better head-coaching hires and successful transfer portal usage helped the Big Ten catch the SEC and enter this season with three consecutive national champions.

The Big Ten's era of dominance might not end anytime soon, either. Ohio State, Oregon and Indiana rank among Athlon's top 10 teams for '26, with USC and Michigan expected to push for playoff spots. Head coach Ryan Day's Buckeyes will be eager to avenge an upset loss to Miami (Fla.) in last season's quarterfinals, while Oregon has its sights set on bringing home the program's first national title. Despite some key personnel departures, Indiana isn't going anywhere behind head coach Curt Cignetti.

Kyle Whittingham's messy breakup with Utah was Michigan's gain. The 66-year-old head coach thrived at maximizing talent in Salt Lake City and now inherits nine returning starters, including former 5-star prospect Bryce Underwood at quarterback.

Add in a Penn State team primed for a rebound under new head coach Matt Campbell, a Top 25 Washington squad, another steady season at Iowa from head coach Kirk Ferentz, an Illinois program that's won 19 games over the last two years, and a UCLA team poised to improve under new head coach Bob Chesney, and the Big Ten now has depth that rivals the SEC.

That depth, plus a couple of national championship contenders, has the potential to solidify the Big Ten's place as the No. 1 conference once again in '26.



3

LSU: COLLEGE FOOTBALL'S BIGGEST SOURCE OF INTRIGUE

Considering the drama that frequently seems to surround both LSU's football program and head coach Lane Kiffin, this duo seems like a perfect pairing. However, the expectations are high for Kiffin. Nick Saban, Les Miles and Ed Orgeron all won national titles. Brian Kelly won 34 games over four seasons before his early dismissal. That wasn't good enough. The Bayou Bengals expect to win national championships.

Kiffin transformed Ole Miss into a College Football Playoff contender during a six-year run, but he left Oxford for LSU and one of the top jobs in the nation. The 51-year-old head coach has a better shot to win a national title in Baton Rouge than at Ole Miss.

The program is also sparing no expense to win a championship. Kiffin reportedly had a \$40 million war chest of NIL funds to use on roster retention, transfers or incoming freshmen. The Tigers deployed those resources to land one of the top transfer hauls of '26, which includes quarterback Sam Leavitt (Arizona State), offensive lineman Jordan Seaton (Colorado), and several impact receivers and defenders to restock two depleted groups.

With wholesale changes coming to the offensive scheme, along with several new faces on the roster, it may take Kiffin and Co. time to get the Tigers firing on all cylinders. However, acclimating new faces every year was a strength for Kiffin at Ole Miss. But this time, the expectations are even higher. And with a nine-game conference slate in the SEC, the margin for error to get to the playoff is even smaller.



4

TEXAS IS READY TO CONTEND — REALLY

Texas is primed to contend for the national championship in '26. No, seriously this time.

It's no secret that Texas was one of college football's biggest disappointments last season. The Longhorns ranked No. 1 in the Associated Press Top 25 preseason poll, and quarterback Arch Manning opened as the Heisman Trophy favorite despite only two starts under his belt. Although Manning rallied late and guided the team to nine victories, it wasn't the season that most anticipated on the Forty Acres.

Fast-forward to '26, and the hype train has already left the station on the Longhorns and their national title hopes. However, this year's team is different. Manning gained confidence late in the year and performed like a future No. 1 NFL Draft pick. Sarkisian supplemented Manning's supporting cast with three impact transfers, including receiver Cam Coleman from Auburn. Also, an offensive line that lacked depth and talent picked up a couple of contributors from the portal.

Knowing that the status quo wasn't enough, Sarkisian took a big swing on defense. In hopes of elevating this unit to the nation's elite, the Longhorns jettisoned coordinator Pete Kwiatkowski in favor of Will Muschamp.

Sarkisian appeared to make all of the right moves after last year's setback. The pressure is on again, however. Contending for the national title is the expectation in '26.

PETRE THOMAS-IMAGN IMAGES

5 DANTE MOORE'S RETURN COULD LIFT OREGON TO ITS FIRST NATIONAL TITLE

Oregon has won plenty of hardware in the modern era of college football, but one major trophy is missing in Eugene: the national championship.

The Ducks have come close to that goal with two appearances in the national title game since 2010. But head coach Dan Lanning's team may have its best shot to win it all in '26 after an off-season of good news. At the NFL Draft deadline, quarterback Dante Moore and four key members of the defensive front — Teitum Tuioti, Matayo Uiagalelei, Bear Alexander and A'Mauri Washington — all opted to return.

Although Moore was far from a finished product, he likely turned down a top-10 draft spot to return in '26. Moore threw for 3,565 yards and 30 touchdowns last season and ranked fourth nationally in completion rate (71.8%). With another year to grow, Moore should be even better, helping to ease the transition to new play-caller Drew Mehringer.

With 15 starters back, the Ducks have few holes on a roster that went to the College Football Playoff semifinals last year and has won 26 games over the past two seasons. But in addition to another top-five recruiting class, Lanning filled roster voids with 16 incoming transfers.

Three different Big Ten teams have claimed national titles over the past three seasons. With Moore returning, along with a deep and talented roster, Oregon seemingly has all of the pieces in place to extend the Big Ten's title run and add the missing trophy to one of college football's most successful programs in the modern era.



6 IS TEXAS TECH PULLING AHEAD IN THE BIG 12?

After expansion to 16 teams prior to the 2024 season, the prevailing thought was that the Big 12 would be unpredictable and likely have no dominant program. The unpredictable part held true, but the combination of the transfer portal and NIL deployment allowed Texas Tech to emerge as the clear top program in the conference. The Red Raiders dominated the league in '25 in winning their first Big 12 title.

And they're not going away. Head coach Joey McGuire's program invested heavily in portal acquisitions to restock a defensive front that lost All-Americans in edge rusher David Bailey and linebacker Jacob Rodriguez.

One caveat: Tech transfer quarterback Brendan Sorsby's eligibility is in question due to a gambling investiga-

tion, leaving the door open to challengers. BYU returns quarterback Bear Bachmeier and is eager for revenge after two blowout losses to the Red Raiders last season. How Utah navigates the coaching transition from Kyle Whittingham to Morgan Scalley is a question mark, but the Utes always seem to find the right pieces. Houston won 10 games in head coach Willie Fritz's second year and brought back quarterback Conner Weigman among 12 returning starters.

In true Big 12 fashion, a dark-horse contender could emerge. Perhaps Oklahoma State with new head coach Eric Morris and transfer quarterback Drew Mestemaker? Or Kansas State with new head coach Collin Klein developing talented senior Avery Johnson into a superstar QB?



7

CAN INDIANA GO BACK-TO-BACK?

After head coach Curt Cignetti engineered arguably the greatest turnaround in college football history and won Indiana's first national championship in football, going back-to-back would seemingly be impossible for this program. But doubt Cignetti at your own risk.

Replicating last year's run to the title won't be easy, but Indiana has plenty of staying power and ability to fight a history that has witnessed only two programs (Alabama and Georgia) win back-to-back championships since 1998. Cignetti is one of the best evaluators of talent in college football, while coordinators Mike Shanahan (offense) and Bryant Haines (defense) thrive at getting the most out of their players.

A plethora of key players, including quarterback Fernando Mendoza, receivers Elijah Sarratt and Omar Cooper Jr., center Pat Coogan and four key starters on defense, departed after '25. However, Cignetti landed a standout portal class to restock both sides of the ball, and 10 total starters return to provide a solid foundation.

TCU transfer quarterback Josh Hoover should be an outstanding fit for Cignetti's offense, and the supporting cast is strong with Charlie Becker and transfer wideout Nick Marsh (Michigan State) on the outside, along with three returning starters in the trenches. Haines' defense has experience at all three levels and dipped into the portal to restock up front and in the secondary.

The schedule allows time for Cignetti to find the right lineup. Indiana should start 6-0 before a showdown with Ohio State in Bloomington on Oct. 17, followed by a road trip to Michigan the following Saturday.

Going 16-0 for the second year in a row seems unlikely. However, as the key new faces get acclimated, and Cignetti pushes the right buttons on both sides of the ball, the Hoosiers will be a threat once again to make a deep College Football Playoff run.

8

WHAT'S NEXT FOR NORTH CAROLINA IN YEAR 2 UNDER BILL BELICHICK?

The early returns on the Bill Belichick experiment at North Carolina left a lot to be desired. The Tar Heels finished 4-8 and won only two ACC games. The offense averaged a paltry 19.3 points per game and was one of the least explosive units in the nation.

Whether it was the constant drama, poor on-field play or the questionable ability to adapt to the college game, Belichick's first season did nothing to quell doubts about his hire. Also, the Tar Heels didn't opt for a quick fix. Instead, North Carolina brought in more than 40 incoming freshmen. One area where Belichick did seek instant help was on offense. Long-time offensive coor-

dinator Bobby Petrino was hired to jumpstart things, and well-traveled quarterback Billy Edwards Jr. arrived from the transfer portal after a stint at Wisconsin to bring needed stability under center.

In addition to a roster in transition once again, the schedule is more challenging than it was in '25. The Tar Heels play TCU in Ireland to open the season, with road dates at Clemson, Pitt and Duke on tap. Notre Dame, Miami (Fla.), Louisville and NC State visit Chapel Hill.

With Belichick making more than \$10 million per season, another losing record and limited on-field progress would prompt plenty of questions about where this experiment is headed.

MARK J. REBILAS-IMAGN IMAGES

9 THE PLAYOFF PATH

Two years of data from the expanded 12-team College Football Playoff field isn't enough to draw sweeping conclusions. However, that short window of time has provided a glimpse of what could be coming this fall.

Only four teams — Oregon, Georgia, Ohio State and Indiana — qualified for both 12-team fields. With the massive roster changes every year due to the transfer portal, the path to a playoff spot is as wide open as ever for a first-time contender or a repeat appearance by last year's new faces.

A breakthrough by a newcomer isn't guaranteed, especially with '25 first-time playoff teams Ole Miss, Texas A&M and Oklahoma all primed to contend for the 12-team field once again. Ole Miss head coach Pete Golding retained quarterback Trinidad Chambliss and running back Kewan Lacy, and momentum is already high for the new era after two playoff wins last season. Quarterback play at Texas A&M (Marcel Reed) and Oklahoma (John Mateer) looms large for both programs' hopes of another berth in the 12-team field.

The most obvious first-time playoff candidates in '26 include a BYU squad that's been knocking on the door in each of the past two years. If new coordinator Gary Patterson can fix the defense, USC has the offensive firepower to join the field from a crowded Big Ten.

So which longshot teams could surprise with a breakthrough playoff appearance? A pair of programs with new head coaches — Florida (Jon Sumrall) or Virginia Tech (James Franklin) — could top the list. Louisville is always a factor in the wide-open ACC, and South Carolina could surprise if head coach Shane Beamer's offseason offensive changes pay off in a big way.

10

KALEN DEBOER'S CRUCIAL THIRD SEASON AT BAMA

Kalen DeBoer's résumé at Alabama — a 20-8 record with one SEC Championship Game and College Football Playoff appearance — is a two-year run that many teams in college football would take. But Alabama is no ordinary program, and DeBoer had the impossible assignment of replacing Nick Saban, arguably the greatest coach in college football history.

The '26 campaign marks a crucial point of DeBoer's tenure. The trademark physicality and rushing attack Alabama is known for were missing in '25. The Crimson Tide finished 15th in the SEC in rushing and ranked 13th in sacks allowed (32). Five-star freshman Ezavier Crowell could provide a much-needed big-play threat in the backfield, but a greater concern is how a completely revamped offensive line meshes this offseason.

DeBoer and offensive coordinator Ryan Grubb have a strong track record of quarterback development, and two intriguing candidates in Austin Mack and former touted 5-star prospect Keelon Russell will battle for the job this fall. Whichever quarterback starts will need receiver Ryan Coleman-Williams to bounce back after an up-and-down sophomore campaign.

Alabama enters '26 with more concerns than at any time in recent memory. This season, it's important for DeBoer, who signed a new seven-year contract that will pay him \$12.5 million per season, to show that the program is still on solid footing and poised to reload and contend once again in the SEC.



11 CAN DEION GET COLORADO BACK ON TRACK?

Life after Travis Hunter and Shedeur Sanders was expected to be challenging for Colorado in 2025. However, the drop-off to 3-9 and just one win in Big 12 play was a steeper regression than most anticipated.

Head coach Deion Sanders isn't on the hot seat, but the urgency to get this program back on track was evident this offseason. Another massive roster overhaul came via the portal. For the fourth consecutive year, the Buffaloes reeled in more than 30 transfers. Additionally, Coach Prime retooled his staff. Both sides of the ball feature new play-callers, with Chris Marve promoted to handle defensive signals and former Sacramento State head coach Brennan Marion bringing his innovative Go-Go offense to Boulder.

Although only four starters return, and there are gaping holes to plug on defense, the cupboard isn't empty. Redshirt freshman quarterback Julian Lewis is promising and should be a good fit for Marion's offense. Additionally, San José State transfer receiver Danny Scudero led the nation with 1,297 receiving yards last year and is among the Big 12's top incoming portal additions.

Colorado's slate is full of toss-up games, bringing the likelihood of several close contests. Sanders overcame a serious health issue to coach all 12 games for the Buffaloes in '25. If the changes fail to turn this program around, there will be plenty of concerns that the '24 success was just a one-year mirage — and doubts as to whether Sanders is the right coach to navigate another rebuild.



12

PRESSURE BUILDING AT CLEMSON

Is the 2026 season the start of a comeback for Clemson and head coach Dabo Swinney? Or perhaps the beginning of the end?

The Tigers were arguably the biggest disappointment in college football last season. After an ACC title and College Football Playoff trip in '24, the return of 14 starters and plenty of star power on both sides of the ball positioned Swinney's program as one of the favorites to win it all in '25. But instead of building on the '24 postseason showing, the Tigers slumped to 7-6 overall.

In an effort to get the program back on track, Swinney passed on fresh ideas and doubled down on familiarity. Chad Morris returns as offensive coordinator after a prolific run from 2011-14, with former players Tajh Boyd and Nolan Turner promoted to full-time roles on the staff.

However, the urgency of getting back on track in '26 was underscored by the largest portal class under Swinney, with 10 incoming transfers.

With only eight returning starters, Clemson's roster has more question marks than in recent years. There's a new quarterback (Christopher Vizzina), three starters gone up front and holes to fill at every level on defense.

Swinney's run of six consecutive top-five finishes and double-digit win seasons (2015-20) is tough to replicate in the current era of college football. Additionally, Swinney has been slow at times to adapt to the transfer portal/NIL era. Were the offseason changes enough to get back on track? Or is Clemson set for another disappointing record, which raises plenty of questions about Swinney's future? The '26 season will be telling.

13

RETURN OF THE PAC-12, GROUP OF 6 REALIGNMENT AND FBS NEWCOMERS

The one constant in college football in recent years has been change. Although the power conferences were quiet on the realignment front this offseason, there was movement in the Group of 6 leagues.

After a two-year hiatus, the Pac-12 returns as a full football conference with eight members in '26. The Mountain West was hit hard by departures with Boise State, Fresno State, Colorado State, San Diego State and Utah State leaving to join Oregon State and Washington

State in the revamped league. Texas State also left the Sun Belt to join the Pac-12.

The Mountain West responded by adding UTEP (Conference USA) and Northern Illinois (MAC) and convincing 10-time FCS champion North Dakota State to make the jump to the FBS. The Sun Belt also raided CUSA, adding Louisiana Tech to replace Texas State as its 14th member.

FBS membership grew to 138 teams when the MAC accepted Sacramento State on a five-year, financially friendly deal.



14

A USC BREAKTHROUGH?

Lincoln Riley's arrival brought high expectations and raised the bar for a USC program looking to rejoin the nation's elite. So far, the results have been mixed. The Trojans won 11 games and played for the Pac-12 title in Riley's debut but are just 24-15 over the past three seasons.

With the program fully acclimated to the Big Ten, ample resources provided for NIL and staffing and the No. 1 recruiting class arriving in '26, Riley has all of the pieces to deliver on the optimism his hire brought prior to the '22 season.

Is the '26 campaign the start of a return to national prominence under Riley? Or will this season only lead to more questions? The Trojans return 14 starters from last year's nine-win team, including quarterback Jayden Maiava and all five offensive linemen. Standout receivers Makai Lemon and Ja'Kobi Lane will be missed, but Riley's track record suggests that the offense won't miss a beat.

However, Riley's defenses have lagged, and it remains the team's biggest weakness in '26. Although the Trojans made small gains under former coordinator D'Anton Lynn, his departure to Penn State allowed Riley to lure former TCU head coach Gary Patterson back to an on-field role as the team's play-caller. Five starters are back, but Patterson has holes to fill at every level on a unit that allowed 5.8 yards per snap in Big Ten play.

USC has a challenging schedule with Ohio State, Indiana and Oregon all appearing on the '26 slate. But if the defense improves, the Trojans seemingly have all of the components for the program's first College Football Playoff trip, which would certainly cool the pressure on Riley in a critical fifth season.



15 SUNSHINE STATE INTRIGUE

Intrigue is never in short supply for the "Big Three" in the Sunshine State. That's especially true entering '26.

Until last season, Florida, Florida State and Miami hadn't figured prominently in the College Football Playoff conversation in recent years. However, "The U" returned to national prominence with three playoff victories and a four-quarter battle with Indiana in the national championship game. Head coach Mario Cristobal's elite recruiting and precise portal additions have solidified Miami as the team to beat in the ACC once again. Duke transfer Darian Mensah was a huge late pickup from the portal to replace Carson Beck under center. Receiver Malachi Toney returns after a breakout freshman campaign, and Cristobal should once again find the right answers in the trenches. As last year's playoff run showed, the Canes are back as a national power and a threat to win it all once again in '26.

The outlook isn't as rosy on the other side of the state. FSU head coach Mike Norvell is squarely on the hot seat after back-to-back losing seasons. And if it weren't for a hefty buyout, the Seminoles likely would've shopped for a new coach in an active carousel. A winning season would certainly cool the pressure on Norvell. However, a challenging schedule and plenty of roster concerns have yielded low expectations in '26.

A promising new era is underway in Gainesville. New head coach Jon Sumrall is an SEC veteran and was successful at two different jobs (Tulane and Troy) in the conference footprint. Sumrall inherited a talented roster and made two of the best coordinator hires in the nation by bringing Buster Faulkner (Georgia Tech) and Brad White (Kentucky) to Florida. The odds of a turnaround seem high in Year 1. A nine-win season is within reach if the Gators find the right answers on a rebuilt offensive line and pick the right quarterback.



A conversation with

CURT CIGNETTI

Indiana has turned the page on 2025,
but Cignetti's Hoosiers aren't going anywhere

Curt Cignetti has “spring anxiety” every year — even this year, after guiding Indiana to its first national championship. The coach who changed everything at IU has fully turned the page on a 16-0 season that set records and revised what’s possible in a sport normally dominated by a small group of programs that have been there and done that.

Indiana did it all in 2025, putting together one of the greatest seasons in college football history, but Cignetti is fully focused on the follow-up. The Hoosiers have positioned themselves to remain in the national title race. They retained all three coordinators, including Broyles Award winner Bryant Haines on defense, and had only one staff change for the second straight year. They bring back top players on both sides of the ball and made significant portal additions, such as quarterback Josh Hoover (TCU), wide receiver Nick Marsh (Michigan State), guard Joe Brunner (Wisconsin) and edge rushers Joshua Burnham from Notre Dame and Tobi Osunsanmi and Chiddi Obiazor from Kansas State.

But Cignetti is still antsy, after a spring when Indiana was shorthanded on offense and breaking in Hoover and other key newcomers. The Hoosiers must replace quarterback Fernando Mendoza, their first Heisman Trophy winner and No. 1 overall NFL draft pick, as well as All-America defenders D'Angelo Ponds and Aiden Fisher, wide receivers Omar Cooper Jr. and Elijah Sarratt and other standouts.

Cignetti spoke with *Athlon Sports* about what has changed at Indiana, what has remained the same and turning the page to the 2026 season.

Athlon Sports: What do you sense could be the personality of this year's team, or some of the things that have changed the most, just given the roster changes?

Curt Cignetti: Every year, you start over, and nowadays in college football, you've got a lot of new faces. We have a lot of new faces, obviously, my first year, last year and this year. You're kind of developing guys — how you practice, standards (besides scheme), how you want to play the game. The practices have been clean, crisp, and I like the competition. They're far from perfect. We've got a

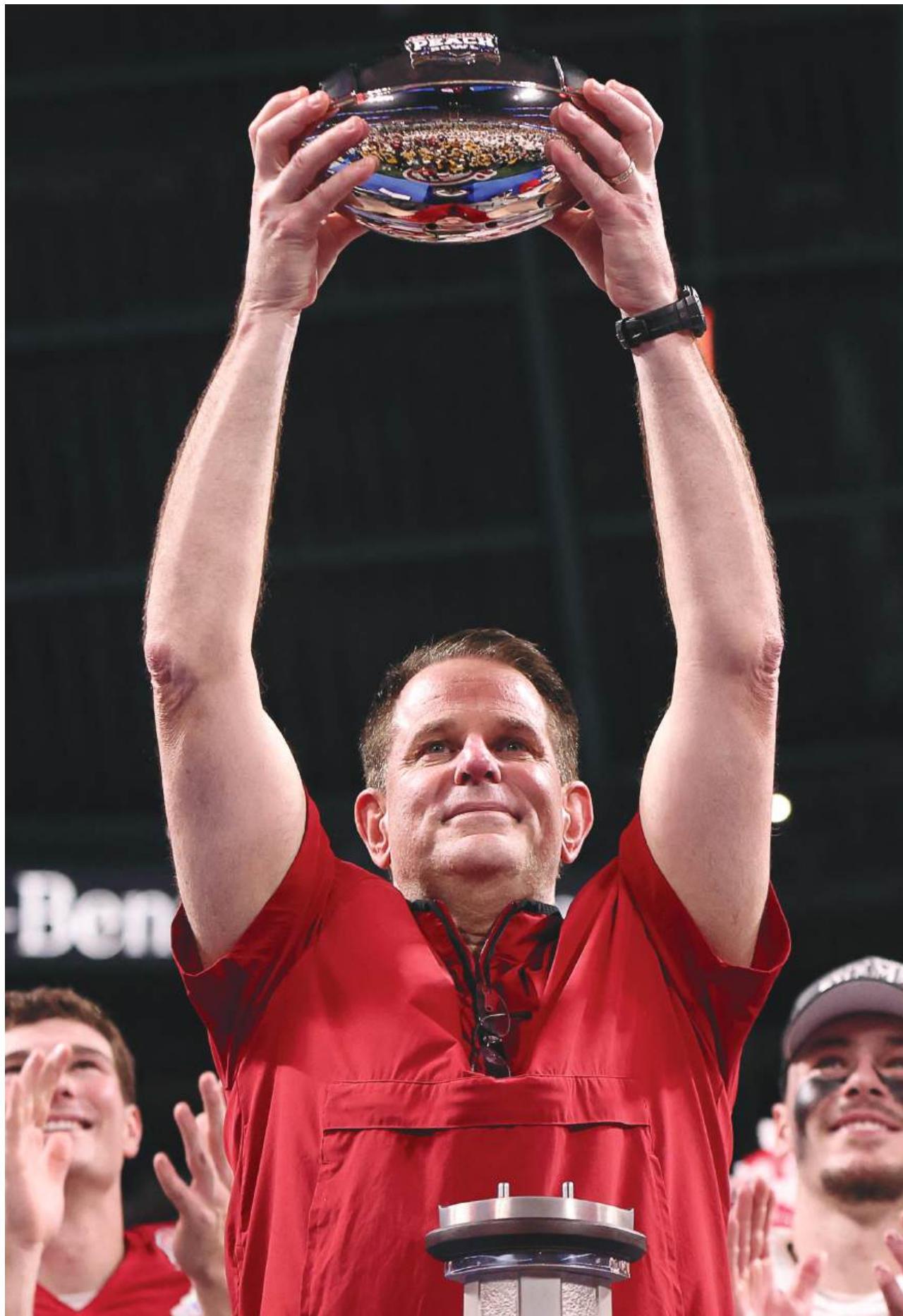
lot of work to do in the fall because the team's going to look a lot different in the fall. But in terms of the mindset and the work ethic and the way they're getting after it in practice, I think they're on par.

“
**ANYTIME
YOU DO
SOMETHING
TWICE, YOU'RE
BETTER THE
SECOND TIME.**

When you achieve what you've achieved, is it easier to turn the page or harder?

Obviously, a lot of people on the outside are still celebrating our success, and maybe the administration and people at the university, but in the building you flip the page. I think we've done a good job of that, I really

do. There's a lot of work to be done. Everybody's 0-0 right now. All the new guys that are out there have done some good things and some not-so-good things, and usually they have a great summer, and they're a different guy in fall camp and during the season. We're counting on them being on the same trajectory as the other ones, but I don't notice anybody resting on their laurels.



BRETT DAVIS-IMAGN IMAGES



Who do you lean on for leadership?

It's early right now. Leadership develops a lot more in fall camp and then in-season. But right now, you're looking at guys like [LB] Isaiah Jones, [DT] Tyrique Tucker, [C] Drew Evans, [OT] Carter Smith.

Offensive line was a group you wanted to augment a little bit. What do you sense with that group?

We return four guys who have started a lot of games, and [tackle Adedamola] Ajani started games last year; he's a little younger. Now it's a matter of who's going to be number six, seven and eight, and we've got young guys who have developed and can fit in those roles.

Who has stood out among your transfers?

The two Kansas State guys, the

D-ends [Tobi Osunsanmi and Chiddi Obiazor], I've noticed them really starting to take a step. Turbo [Richard] is very consistent at running back. [OG] Joe Brunner from Wisconsin. The safety from Wisconsin, [Preston] Zachman, is making nice progress. Yeah. Both receivers — Shazz [Preston] and [Nick] Marsh — can help us.

What is unique about Josh Hoover's skill set that's different from the last two quarterbacks you've had?

He's a quick thinker who has played a lot of football. He moves better than [Kurtis] Rourke, but Rourke has some natural quarterback instincts that Josh has, too. Fernando [Mendoza], he's 6-foot-5, could really move. We've always tilted more toward the run in terms of the run-pass ratio, although in compet-

itive situations last year, we're about 50-50. You factor in the RPO game, the advanced throws, which should be easy completions. Whereas, where [Hoover] came from, they're throwing the ball about 60% of the time. It'll be a lot different for him, more advantageous. He did turn the ball over at TCU, so we're going to have to do a great job of protecting the ball.

Everyone's trying to replicate what you guys did. What have you learned about this place and the way that it's set up as a university, as an alumni base, even after the fact, that's contributed to where you guys sit right now?

This doesn't get done without the commitment from the top. [University president] Pam Whitten grew up in the South. She loves football, she's

RICH JANZARUK/HERALD-TIMES



THE CIGNETTI FILE

- Career Record: 146-37 (.797 winning percentage)
- 53-17 at Div. II IUP (2011-16)
- 14-9 at FCS Elon (2017-18)
- 33-5 at FCS James Madison (2019-21)
- 19-4 at FBS James Madison (2022-23)
- 27-2 at Indiana (2024-25)
- Led the Hoosiers to the first 16-0 season in college football history
- Coached Indiana's first Heisman Trophy winner, QB Fernando Mendoza, who was one of two consensus IU All-Americans in 2025, joining OT Carter Smith
- Two-time AP Coach of the Year (2024, 2025)
- Paul "Bear" Bryant National Coach of the Year (2025)
- Two-time Big Ten Coach of the Year (2024, 2025)
- Winner of five conference championships (one Div. II Pennsylvania State Athletic Conference, three FCS Colonial Athletic, one Big Ten)
- In four seasons as an assistant coach under Nick Saban at Alabama (2007-10), the Crimson Tide posted a 42-11 record (including a 29-game regular-season winning streak) and won a national championship
- Helped recruit and develop key Crimson Tide players such as Heisman Trophy-winning RB Mark Ingram II and WR Julio Jones
- In addition to Saban, coached under Bobby Bowden (West Virginia) and Chuck Amato (NC State)

committed to see it go. I think once everybody saw what football could do for the university, the town, the alumni base, the state and nationally, once we started winning, they kept pouring more and more in. Her and [athletic director] Scott [Dolson], I just really respect both of them a lot; we're totally aligned. The alignment is the key, and then the staff continuity has been really critical for me.

You mentioned the continuity. You know how this business is — it's so hard to keep assistants. What would you say have been the biggest factors in the fact that the staff has barely changed?

It's just been such a unique journey. So you hire [current defensive coordinator Bryant] Haines and [current offensive coordinator Mike] Shanahan as part-time coaches for

under \$10,000, and you keep moving on, right? And we keep winning, and their jobs improve, and their salaries improve, and I think there's a loyalty and they like the way we do things. They've got free time, too. I'm not keeping them in the office from 6 a.m. to 11 at night. So I think that's why they've stayed when they've had opportunities to leave.

You mentioned that a lot of times your teams get better in the summer. Why does that happen?

The summer, the strength and conditioning staff handles that. And then there's 7-on-7 and things like that. And they've gone through the spring, they've been through the plays one time. They're getting bigger, stronger, faster, again, kind of bonding in the summer, getting to know each other better. And then in fall camp, it's the second time through.

Anytime you do something twice, you're better the second time. Last year's team did a great job — their consistency, day in, day out, was the best I've had. Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday, having the mindset on Friday and then putting it between the white lines, like we asked him to, doing the things we asked him to do. You know, fast, physical, relentless, that whole thing, smart, disciplined, poised, not affected by success or failure, never satisfied until the end, one play at a time, six seconds a play. A play has a life and a history of its own. But that team was extremely consistent day in, day out. And you know, it helps to have guys who are smart and combine the team concept, and then you develop that togetherness and belief.

WHATEVER HAPPENED TO THE



You remember. The Strength Everywhere Conference of Saban, Sankey and Smart. The league that produced Heisman Trophies and high draft picks. The football consortium that had been hoarding national championships at a record pace since before some current freshmen were born. What used to be the center of the college football universe. That Southeastern Conference.

It can now be logically concluded that the SEC is in a slump. Or a downturn. Or a recession, or whatever you want to call it. Maybe something worse.

It's no longer just a talking point. It's a football fact. After winning 13 titles in 17 years, the SEC has missed the national championship game three years in a row for the first time since 2001. That's a nice, tidy introduction to a story that will help define the 2026 season and beyond.



The Big Ten has eclipsed college football's former behemoth.
Can the SEC reclaim its throne?

BY DENNIS DODD

This account doesn't get past the intro without mentioning the Big Ten's role in what is increasingly looking like a takeover. The league has won three consecutive football national championships for the first time since 1942. For starters. Mix in Michigan hoops, and the Big Ten holds the men's basketball and football championships simultaneously for the first time since 1960 — or since a sophomore named Bob Knight was coming off the bench for Ohio State, and since the immortal Murray Warmath led the Minnesota Golden Gophers to the Rose Bowl.

Throw in UCLA women's hoops, and the Big Ten is the first Division I conference with three different schools winning in football and men's and women's basketball in the same academic year.

For those used to the lofty, sweet home Southern standard the SEC

has set all these years, these are tough times.

"I'm sitting in Birmingham right now across from SEC headquarters," radio and television personality Paul Finebaum told *Athlon Sports* during the offseason. "I can't speak for them, but I can speak for myself. I can tell you there is real concern."

"It was part of our psyche that we were better, and we wore it on our sleeve. We would tell anybody who would listen. This is a shock to the system."

At worst, the SEC has been lapped by its chief conference rival. For the moment, the Big Ten has cracked the code on NIL, the transfer portal, player development, program building and return on recruiting investment.

Finebaum, ESPN's face-of-the-conference who appears daily on the SEC Network spreading the league's good word as if it were biblical revelation, is not the only one who's noticed.

"Michigan was one thing," Finebaum said of the Wolverines' 2023 title. "Ohio State [in 2024]. But then Indiana. Nobody down here respects Indiana."

They may be starting to, especially after the Hoosiers' 38-3 clubbing of Alabama in the College Football Playoff Rose Bowl quarterfinal. A school from the county seat of Monroe County, Indiana, buzz-sawing its way to a national championship through the Crimson Tide was a helmet slap for the entire SEC.

"That to me was the Waterloo," Finebaum added. "Watching that destruction. Watching Alabama players quit in the fourth quarter. I've never encountered anything like that."

Other cracks are showing.

When the Big Ten's USC finished with the nation's No. 1 recruiting class in 2026 per *247Sports*, that ended a run of 18 years with SEC schools holding the No. 1 spot in that ranking.

The SEC just finished with its all-time worst single-season bowl record at 2-8. The conference was favored to win seven of the 10

games (not counting the head-to-head matchup between Oklahoma and Alabama in the playoff).

In 2024, SMU — in its first year in the ACC — was selected to the CFP over Alabama. A case could have been made for and against the Tide after a 9-4 season, but the fact that SMU — which had spent almost four decades wandering in the wilderness outside power conference football — made such an impression on the selection committee was significant.



It was part of our psyche that we were better, and we wore it on our sleeve. We would tell anybody who would listen.

This is a shock to the system.

— PAUL FINEBAUM

Not surprisingly, the pressure to win in the SEC has never been more intense. Since the beginning of 2022, nine of 16 schools have changed coaches at least once. In one two-day period last year (Nov. 30-Dec. 1), six SEC schools announced new football coaches. In Saban's 17 seasons at Alabama, the other SEC schools hired 54 different coaches.

The guy to follow the guy, Kalen DeBoer, has yet to fully prove himself at Alabama. Brian Kelly didn't get it done at LSU. Lane Kiffin had sure as hell better. Steve Sarkisian has to win a championship at some point at Texas to be considered a success in Austin, doesn't he? Florida and Auburn continue to struggle. Ryan Silverfield is Arkansas' third head coach since 2019.

And it may be a while before the SEC's prestige is restored. It's hard

to find an SEC team in Vegas with a projected double-digit win total in 2026. Georgia and Texas are typically the leaders in that category at 9.5.

Also, the decision to add a ninth conference game means that half the league is guaranteed to have an extra loss beginning this season. No wonder some SEC types are ready to junk the championship game.

It just means *more*.

Finebaum joked on the air last summer that if the Big Ten won another title, he was going to leave the country. "A lot of people took me seriously," he said.

He stayed in the country, but his eyes widened.

"It's got some historical feeling about it," Finebaum said of the current state of the SEC. "How could this happen to us?"

For one, Big Ten commissioner Tony Petitti happened. The 65-year-old son of a New York City cop is a TV guy. He came up as a sports executive at CBS, ABC and Major League Baseball. His best college experience was programming college football, not watching the parade go by.

He's an innovator for whom bigger is better. Petitti secured Oregon and Washington in the last round of expansion. He floated the idea of Big Ten play-in games for the playoff. His 24-team playoff model that was circulated in the offseason makes too much sense.

That idea is also in direct conflict with his peer, SEC commissioner Greg Sankey. The ongoing King Kong-vs.-Godzilla battle for sport's levers of power continues.

Jim Harbaugh also happened.

The Big Ten's rise and the SEC's slide both occurred about the same time that legal player compensation started.

Michigan's quirky coach embraced NIL in 2023. Not surprisingly, that same year Harbs survived questions about his job security and won it all in his ninth season with the Wolverines. Pay no attention to his treading all over the NCAA rulebook amid multiple scandals

and suspensions to get to the top.

Most telling, Harbaugh sledgehammered home a style that had been perfected by the SEC. Physical. Conservative. Dominant at the line of scrimmage. Almost boring when it was all clicking. Devastating when Michigan football became an SEC doppelgänger.

Ryan Day also happened. In 2024, Ohio State had to mentally recover from a crippling loss to Michigan in order to win it all. In the space of seven weeks, the Buckeyes' head coach went from whispers of being let go to national champion. He remains the game's winningest active coach.

In 2024, Curt Cignetti came out of nowhere. (OK, technically, he came from James Madison.) It can be sensibly argued that Indiana's success caused a nationwide panic beyond the SEC with administrators everywhere asking, "Why can't we do that?"

Why, indeed? It can be argued the SEC began its current downturn on Jan. 10, 2024, the day Nick Saban retired. That moment was always going to come for the greatest college coach of all time as he eased into his 70s. But when it did, it was still a shock to the SEC's soul.

Saban's brilliance in recruiting, player development and strategy was unmatched. His influence is scattered all over the game in the form of scores of assistants who learned at his feet.

But Saban had tired of the NIL landscape. And unfortunately, there was no one to replace him. Not yet. Not at that level.

The Big Ten has pulled off a lightning-fast renovation. Once mocked for its slow, plodding style of play, the league — at least at the top — has taken over the game.

A year after tying its own record of 15 first-round NFL Draft picks in 2025, the SEC has lost its draft domination. Ohio State alone had more top-11 picks (four) than the entire SEC combined (one).

After not having a quarterback go No. 1 overall in the draft since 1990 (Jeff George, Illinois), Big Ten quarterbacks have been the No. 1

pick two of the last three seasons. In April, Fernando Mendoza was the No. 1 overall pick of the Las Vegas Raiders. USC's Caleb Williams went No. 1 overall to the Chicago Bears in 2024.

The SEC is in the midst of its longest championship drought since 1999–2002. We are long since past the point of asking what went wrong in the SEC and how to fix it.



Kalen DeBoer has yet to fully prove himself at Alabama. Brian Kelly didn't get it done at LSU. Lane Kiffin had sure as



hell better. Steve Sarkisian has to win a championship at some point at Texas to be considered a success in Austin, doesn't he? Florida and Auburn continue to struggle. Ryan Silverfield is Arkansas' third head coach since 2019.

Everything in college football is cyclical, from style of play to style of polo shirts worn by assistants. What we are witnessing is something more significant. College athletics is in a period of peak disruption.

The urgency and ability to acquire plug-and-play transfers are at odds with the timeworn — and, some believe, time-sucking — practice of developing high school talent. The likes of Indiana, Ohio State and Michigan have maintained roster consistency better than anyone lately.

Meanwhile, the SEC is chasing a legacy instead of creating one. With six championships at Alabama — a record seven overall, including at LSU in 2003 — Saban created a standard that can't be matched. Anywhere. That was a different era.

The most popular term these days is "alignment" — where coach, AD and president all agree on the mission, money and moxie it takes to make it all work.

As a result, in a sport that has never embraced underdogs, the portal and NIL have brought a form of parity that never existed in college football. Vanderbilt stuck a foot in the door. James Madison and Tulane got to the College Football Playoff. Hired less than three months apart, Indiana's Curt Cignetti (football) and Michigan's Dusty May (basketball) each took their programs from the bottom of the Big Ten to a national championship in two years on the job.

The SEC's current situation crystallized in late 2023 when an Alabama staffer turned to me in the run-up to that season's CFP semifinal Rose Bowl against Michigan. "We've only got one billionaire in Alabama," he complained. "They've got seven at [the University of] Texas."

A few days later, Saban coached his last game.

CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: KIRBY LEE-IMAGN IMAGES; STEPHEN LEW-IMAGN IMAGES; MATTHEW HINTON-IMAGN IMAGES; BRETT ROJO-IMAGN IMAGES; PETRE THOMAS-IMAGN IMAGES

"Adapt or die," Texas head coach Steve Sarkisian has repeatedly said of the current landscape.

Michigan adapted during the summer of 2024. The program realized it had to get into the NIL game after 5-star quarterback Bryce Underwood had committed to LSU.

It (eventually) became unacceptable to Michigan that Underwood, from nearby Belleville, Michigan, would leave for the SEC, especially with the Wolverines needing a quarterback. Billionaire Michigan alum Larry Ellison then reportedly ponied up \$10 million for Underwood.

While not a big donor at the beginning of the Cignetti era, Mark Cuban has become another Big Ten billionaire who fuels his alma mater's fortunes.

"I really jumped in because how [Cignetti] approaches building a program. They weren't about, 'OK, give me enough money to win the portal,'" Cuban told CBS Sports HQ. "He had a very specific approach to his culture. ... He said, 'I want production, not future, not potential.'"

Ohio State paid a reported \$20 million for the roster that won the 2024 title. That figure is now outdated. We head into the 2026 season with the top programs paying \$50 million to assemble a top-shelf roster.

Is the SEC all in? Is it heresy to even ask that question? LSU certainly pushed all its chips to the middle of the Death Valley playing surface. It blatantly went after Kiffin, the self-described "Portal King," while he was leading Ole Miss to a playoff berth. Ethics, hurt feelings and financial constraints be damned.

Remember way back four years ago when Tennessee threw \$8 million at quarterback Nico Iamaleava? Hey, nobody said then or now that any of the numbers make sense.

After winning back-to-back national titles in 2021-22, Georgia hasn't advanced past the CFP quarterfinals, even while winning the 2025 SEC title. Sorry, but that's a net decline in Athens.

Whoever replaced Saban wasn't going to measure up. To many al-

ways-rational Bama fans — sarcasm tag added — DeBoer certainly hasn't, despite a playoff appearance in his second season.

"There is still an arrogance [among SEC fans]," Finebaum said. "Alabama fans are probably having the hardest time."

Parity has allowed any program to get players from anywhere as long as the fit, alignment and money are right. Ohio State enticed Alabama freshman All-America safety Caleb Downs to transfer after Saban retired. May's starting five at Michigan were all transfers.

What the Big Ten has been able to do lately is bridge the mysterious gap between player compensation and success on the field.

"You still need great coaching," Petitti told Front Office Sports. "You still need a commitment to winning, and performing at the high level, coming together, and building and developing players. I don't think that's ever going to change."

The Big Ten, born in a downtown Chicago hotel in 1896, has always been the richest conference. Bigger markets, deeper pockets, bigger alumni bases than anyone else.

It didn't matter very much until the late 1980s, when media rights revenue became an advantage to be exploited. The Big Ten was the first conference to expand in the modern era after the deregulation of college football television when Penn State joined in 1990 (PSU football began conference play in 1993). Former SEC commissioner Roy Kramer followed suit, adding South Carolina and Arkansas in 1992.

The power at the top of college athletics is now consolidated in 34 schools — 18 in the Big Ten, 16 in the SEC. In its latest financial statement, the SEC distributed a record \$1.03 billion (\$72.4 million per school). The Big Ten, whose figures hadn't been released at press time, was expected to distribute \$1.2 billion (\$75 million per school). The Big Ten is expected to be paying \$100 million per school at the end of its current media rights deal early in the next decade.

You can see where this is headed

— a rivalry decided with ruthless hits on the field and monstrous balance sheets off of it.

For the moment, advantage Big Ten. For the first time in the modern age, the league has weaponized its financial advantage.

"A lot of the schools in the Southeastern Conference don't have that kind of old-time generational wealth," Saban said last year.

An SEC lapse was bound to happen. Simple statistical theory states there will always be a regression to the mean. College football wouldn't always be tipped in the SEC's favor. Thirteen championships in 17 years were unprecedented. A confluence of media, coaching, recruiting, player development and fortune has shifted in the Big Ten's favor.

The relationship remains complicated because the leagues are both rivals and partners. They control the size and structure of the playoff on their own. Last year, the rest of the FBS acquiesced to the SEC and Big Ten getting an annual revenue share of 29% of the CFP.

Forget debating whether that was fair or not. It just was. The FBS can't field a legitimate playoff without the two mega-conferences. The SEC and Big Ten have made it clear that they could stage their own 34-team playoff.

"How do we work with col-leagues to solve problems? Can we do that collectively?" Sankey said on Finebaum's show in March. "If there's a point at which we cannot do so, I think the conversation that informs the question that you ask, 'Is there something you'd do alone?' I think that starts to generate more and more interest."

Yikes. As much as they are going at each other's throats, whatever happens in the future of college athletics is going to be manipulated by/guided by the SEC and Big Ten.

So how does the SEC regain its primacy? Win more playoff games for sure. Crack that NIL code. Find the next Mendoza. Gosh, it's been almost three years since the SEC won a Heisman. Maybe keep Kiffin away from a keyboard.

Maybe look more like ... Indiana?